

Pussytoes

Antennaria neglecta

Field Pussytoes · Plantain-leaved Everlasting



QUALITIES

A low evergreen mat-forming perennial of dry prairies and oak openings. Silvery-gray rosettes of small spoon-shaped fuzzy leaves spread by surface runners to form a dense ground-hugging carpet 2 to 4 inches tall. In May, short 4-to-6-inch stalks rise above the foliage bearing tight white fuzzy flower clusters that look uncannily like a kitten's toepads — giving the species its common name.

CARE

Full sun, dry well-drained soil; ideal for sandy or rocky sites and sun-baked margins. Hates wet feet — site away from downspouts and drainage paths. Plant from plug stock 6 to 9 inches apart. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Fully steppable once established — tolerates moderate foot traffic without damage, making it a rare native option for paths, stepping-stone gaps, and service-area buffers.

HISTORY

Pussytoes belong to a group of plants called "everlastings" because the dried flower clusters retain their form and color for years; they were widely used in Victorian dried-flower arrangements and memorial wreaths. Several Plains tribes used a leaf preparation as a remedy for snakebite (largely symbolic) and as a smoke for purification ceremonies. The genus is named *Antennaria* for the flower's resemblance to butterfly antennae.

REASON TO BE

Pussytoes is the larval host plant for the American Lady butterfly (*Vanessa virginiensis*) — caterpillars build silken nests on the silvery foliage. Few native groundcovers tolerate foot traffic, drought, AND host a charismatic butterfly all at once; this one does. In a residential design it solves the problem of "what to plant where service techs walk" — the HVAC buffer, the gas-meter approach — without resorting to non-native ground cover or sterile gravel.